RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

# The Dead Will Rise: Principle 13

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 18

**Source:** The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: Principle 13 (*Techiyat HaMetim*), with the Rambam's ***Ma'amar Techiyat HaMetim***, Mishneh Torah, the Ra'avad, and the other Rishonim

**Shiur:** Part 18 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 24 February 2026 (the week before Purim)

*These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.*

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*The shiur was dedicated לעילוי נשמת יצחק דניאל בן משה זאב. "All the Torah we learn, and all the Torah disseminated through the technology being used: may it be for the elevation of his soul. מן השמים תנוחמו."*

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## Schedule

- **Next week is Purim: no shiur.**
- **In two weeks: one final shiur** on **the Rambam's concluding paragraph**: what follows if one denies any of the principles, and how that applies today. **Then the Moreh.**

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## Part 1: The Text: Two Words

**היסוד השלשה עשר: תחיית המתים. וכבר בארנוה.**

**The thirteenth principle: the resurrection of the dead. We have already explained it.** "**Full stop. That's the end.**"

**"Already explained"**: earlier in the Introduction (we learnt it **around November**, before the winter break), where, discussing **Olam HaBa**, the Rambam also covers **Mashiach, Gan Eden, Gehinnom and *Techiyat HaMetim***:

> **ותחיית המתים יסוד מיסודות תורת משה רבנו עליו השלום, ואין דת ולא דבקות בדת היהודית למי שלא יאמין זה. אבל היא לצדיקים...**

**Resurrection is a foundation of Moshe's Torah**: **no part in the Jewish religion** for one who doesn't believe it. **But it's for the righteous.**

**ודע כי האדם יש לו למות בהכרח, ויפרד וישוב למה שהורכב ממנו.**

**Know that a person must die, separating and returning to what he was composed of.**

"**Perhaps the most illuminating sentence.** We're made **from the dust**. **The righteous will rise again in their bodies, and then die again**, and then go to **Olam HaBa**, which for the Rambam is **purely spiritual**."

### Ani Ma'amin and Yigdal

| | Text |
|---|---|
| **Ani Ma'amin** | **שתהיה תחיית המתים בעת שיעלה רצון מאת הבורא, יתברך שמו ויתעלה זכרו לעד ולנצח נצחים** |
| **Yigdal** | **מתים יחיה אל ברוב חסדו, ברוך עדי עד שם תהלתו** |

"**Basically the same; nothing new.**"

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## Part 2: The Sources

**In Chazal and the liturgy, everywhere**: the **second *berachah* of the Amidah**, three times a day. **In the Torah, nothing explicit**, though many hints; **in Nevi'im and Ketuvim, explicit**.

| Source | Verse | Reading |
|---|---|---|
| **Ha'azinu** (Devarim 32:39) | **ראו עתה כי אני אני הוא ואין אלהים עמדי, אני אמית ואחיה, מחצתי ואני ארפא** | **"I strike and I heal" is the same person**, so **"I kill and I bring to life"** is too. "**The order seems wrong: it should be *I give life and I kill.***" (**Rav Saadia** brings this) |
| **Yeshayahu 26:19** | **יחיו מתיך נבלתי יקומון, הקיצו ורננו שכני עפר** | **Your dead will live; dwellers in the dust, awake and sing** |
| **Daniel 12:2** | **ורבים מישני אדמת עפר יקיצו, אלה לחיי עולם** | **Many who sleep in the dust will awake**, some to **everlasting life** |

### Not reincarnation

**Resurrection** = **the dead come alive again**. **Not *gilgul***, **a soul returning in a new body**: "**clearly the Rambam didn't believe in it**; it **doesn't fit anywhere in his framework** and he **never discusses it**. **Nor did Rav Saadia. There's no traditional source for it.**" A different topic.

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## Part 3: Why So Brief?

"**The question that bothered many since medieval times.**"

| Work | What the Rambam says about resurrection |
|---|---|
| **Commentary on the Mishnah** (this) | **Two words**: *"already explained"* |
| **Mishneh Torah** | Focuses on **Olam HaBa** and **the immortal soul**. **One mention**, in Hilchot Teshuvah 3: no portion for **הכופרים בתחיית המתים ובביאת הגואל** |
| **Moreh Nevuchim** | **Nowhere discussed philosophically**; one **incidental** reference in another context |

**In his lifetime the Rambam was accused of not believing in physical resurrection.**

### The Ra'avad

**The Rambam (Hilchot Teshuvah 8:2): העולם הבא אין בו גוף וגויה... אין בו לא אכילה ולא שתיה... ולא תשמיש המטה, אלא צדיקים יושבין ועטרותיהן בראשיהן ונהנין מזיו השכינה. No body, no eating or drinking: the righteous sit with crowns on their heads, enjoying the radiance of the Shechinah.**

**The Ra'avad** (R. Avraham ben David, "**his harshest critic**"): **אמר אברהם: דברי האיש הזה בעיני קרובים למי שאומר אין תחיית המתים לגופות אלא לנשמות בלבד.**

**"This man's words seem to me close to one who says resurrection is for souls only, not bodies." בחיי ראשי, לא היה זה דעת חכמים**: Chazal say the righteous **rise in their clothes**; they **rise with their blemishes** (a broken leg, a broken hip) **and are then healed**. **וכל אלה מוכיחים כי בגויותיהם עומדים בחיים**.

"**That's essentially the question: did the Rambam believe in a physical resurrection? What *is* the thirteenth principle?**" "**If we didn't have his letter, people would have a point.**"

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## Part 4: *Ma'amar Techiyat HaMetim*

*"Last year we did a series on the Rambam's letters, martyrdom and others. The major one we didn't do was the letter on resurrection."*

### Why he wrote it

- **The Mishneh Torah had spread** to many lands. **A certain *chacham*** ("**from Syria, I think**") cited it to **deny physical resurrection**: **only the soul is immortal**.
- At first he **ignored it**: "**people always misunderstand whatever you write**."
- Then in **1189** a letter **from Yemen**: **many were denying physical resurrection** because he'd written so little. **So he wrote the essay.**

### "However clear you are, people twist your words"

**שמע ישראל ה׳ אלהינו ה׳ אחד. God is one.**Ask any Jew:

**The Christians** of his day: **three names, *Hashem, Elokeinu, Hashem***: **Father, Son and Holy Ghost**; ***echad***: **the Trinity is one**.

"**A verse so clear, so explicit, so unambiguous**, and they made **the unity of God** into **the Trinity**. **What do you want me to do** if people misunderstand **me**?"

### His defence

"**It's not true. I wrote it in my Commentary: it's one of the Thirteen Principles.** I was **brief**" (**he concedes it**). **There will be a physical resurrection.**

| Why so terse? |
|---|
| **A. Brevity is my style.** |
| **B. There's little to say**: it **can't be defended by philosophical investigation**; **it's a matter of belief**. |
| **C. It's not the main thing. The main thing is Olam HaBa**: נהנין מזיו השכינה. "**I don't want people bogged down in resurrection and thinking that's all.**" |

### How it fits

**If Olam HaBa is purely spiritual, what is a physical resurrection for?**

**The dead rise, live a while, die again, and then begin Olam HaBa: "the real McCoy, the final destination."**

### The Rambam's picture, assembled

| Stage | |
|---|---|
| **1** | The righteous die and **begin their Olam HaBa** |
| **2** | **Around the time of Mashiach** (before or after), **here on earth**, **the dead come alive physically** |
| **3** | They **live some time** ("we don't know how long") |
| **4** | They **die again and return to the dust** |
| **5** | **Olam HaBa**: **pure spiritual bliss**, nothing physical |

"**I don't know of any other Rishon who takes this approach.** I think **he's unique**."

*In academia*, some argue **the letter wasn't his real view** but **written for the masses**. "**It's not for me to put a view on that. He wrote it, and we take his words at face value.**"

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## Part 5: Hints of Another Reading

### 1. Professor Marc Shapiro: the order in Hilchot Teshuvah 3

| Halachah | Principles |
|---|---|
| **3:7** | **1–5** |
| **3:8** | **6–9**, and **10** |
| **3:6** | then **12 13**: הכופרים בתחיית המתים ובביאת הגואל |
| — | **11 missing** |

"**Two questions:** where's **11**? (Rav Shilat: it's **a consequence of 10**.) And **why 13 before 12?** Everywhere else **Mashiach comes first**."

**Shapiro's suggestion:** in Mishneh Torah **"*Techiyat HaMetim*" alludes to a spiritual resurrection: the immortality of the soul**, i.e. **Principle 11 (Olam HaBa)**. **That answers both**: **11 is there**, and **the order is 11, 12**. "**Interesting. The problem: he does have Principle 13.**"

## 2. The cemetery blessing (the *Keter Shem Tov*)

**Rav Gaguin**, **Chacham of the Spanish and Portuguese** in the early 1900s, recorded their customs **in seven volumes**.

| | Text |
|---|---|
| **Gemara (Berachot 58b)** | **ברוך... אשר יצר אתכם בדין, וזן אתכם בדין, וכלכל אתכם בדין, והמית אתכם בדין, ויודע מספר כולכם, והוא עתיד להחיותכם ולקיימכם... ברוך אתה ה׳ מחיה המתים** |
| **The Rambam (Hilchot Berachot 10:11)** | **...והמית אתכם בדין, ועתיד להקימכם בדין לחיי העולם הבא...** |

"**Only the Rambam adds *lechayei Olam HaBa*.** There are **many texts** in the Geonim and Rishonim (**I'm looking into this now: I was asked about the text in a certain cemetery**), and **no one else brings in Olam HaBa**."

**But in his letter, resurrection has nothing to do with Olam HaBa**: you come **out** of it, live, die, and go back. **Here he seems to equate them.**

**The Keter Shem Tov ends: והמשכיל יבין.** "**Code words.** When a *chacham* wants to convey something he's **uncomfortable saying outright** (**Ibn Ezra** uses it a lot; ***vehamaskil yidom***: if you're wise, keep quiet). **His book isn't theological; he rarely writes it. I think he was hinting at this.**"

## 3. Chief Rabbi Hertz

**The Hertz Siddur** (used in **most United Synagogues**), **p. 255**: "**Maimonides makes the doctrine of the resurrection of the dead identical with that of the immortality of the soul, and explains the Talmudic sayings to the contrary as figurative language.**"

"**Did Hertz not know of the letter? Of course he knew.**"

## "Why am I telling you this?"

"**Perhaps I should keep quiet: *vehamaskil yavin*.** I'll tell you why. **Let me be very clear: the overwhelming understanding of the Rambam is that the thirteenth principle is belief in a physical resurrection.**"

| The difficulties | The ruling |
|---|---|
| **Philosophically**, how resurrection fits his eschatology **is very difficult** | **He writes very clearly that he believes**, so ***al panav*, our duty is to believe in a physical resurrection.** "**Sometimes we accept what we can't understand.**" |
| **His brevity** everywhere, and **the hints** | |

"**Someone who says *I find physical resurrection difficult; I understand the thirteenth principle as Olam HaBa, spiritual identity: I wouldn't call him a kofer. Deny any of the principles and you are a kofer***, with **many sanctions** (our final shiur). **But this, I personally wouldn't**, given everything we've seen."

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## Part 6: The Other Views

| | **The Rambam** | **The Ramban** (with R. Meir HaLevi / the **Ramah**; articulated by **the Ramchal** and **the Kabbalah**) | **Rav Saadia Gaon** (and other Rishonim) |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Order** | Resurrection **in this world**, then **death**, then **Olam HaBa** | Mashiach (12) → death → **the world ends → resurrection ushers in Olam HaBa** | **Two resurrections** |
| **Olam HaBa is...** | **Souls only** | **Body and soul together** | |
| **The body** | Returns to dust | **Our own bodies**, "**you'll see your flesh**," but **refined and elevated** | |
| **After** | | **Live forever** | **1st**, at **Mashiach's** time, **for the righteous of Israel**; **2nd**, after the world ends, **for all with a portion in Olam HaBa, including non-Jews** |
| **Strength** | | "**Philosophically very cogent**," though **a physical Olam HaBa** is **a strong question** for the Rambam | (We learnt it in ***Emunot veDe'ot***) |

### Albo: "When they come alive, we'll know"

**Sefer HaIkkarim IV:35: הדבר הזה חלקו בו גדולי האחרונים.**

- **The Rambam "and many sages with him": the dead, once revived, will use all their physical senses as is normal, then die and return to dust.**

- **R. Meir HaLevi, the Ramah and the Ramban**: they'll live **their natural span**, and **then their bodies will be refined like Eliyahu and Chanoch**, **body and soul**, **enjoying the radiance of the Shechinah**, **sustained forever without food or drink**.

"Strange, but possible." **Which is right? התשובה לכל זה וכיוצא בו היא כמו שהשיב רבי יהושע בן חנניה לאנשי אלכסנדריא: כשיחיו נחכם להם.**

**When they come alive, we'll know.** "**So much ambiguity: when, how, where it falls in the framework. Don't worry about it. You don't need to know.**"

**The takeaway:** "**There is a thirteenth principle: belief in a physical resurrection of the dead. When, why, how: different views.** Someone who believes **only in a spiritual resurrection** I wouldn't call a *kofer*, **but one can't go against the Rambam's plain words in his letter**. **Prima facie, it's physical.**"

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## Part 7: Questions

**Robert:** *Does the Rambam hold people keep being born after* Techiyat HaMetim*, and so miss it, since it's a once-in-history event?*

"**I'm almost sure the Rambam doesn't discuss it anywhere. Rav Saadia** does: **they'll marry, have children, live long. But if Mashiach came now, you and I wouldn't experience it either**: we're alive. **It's for those who died. I don't see an issue.**"

***Will they wake up to strangers*, a hundred or two hundred years on? *As a baby or an old person?***

"Rav Saadia happens to say **you'll meet your family**, **but that's not the point**. **Not as a baby: some kind of adult. When it happens, we'll worry about it.**"

***Is it like Mashiach, believe but don't calculate?***

"**You're right.**" Even **Olam HaBa**, the Rambam says, is like **describing colours to someone blind from birth**: "**how do you explain red and green?**" **But he spends ages on Olam HaBa** because **it's the ultimate**. **Mashiach and *Techiyat HaMetim* are principles of faith, but compared to Olam HaBa, far lower.** "**The Rambam says it about Mashiach, Albo about resurrection, and I think the Rambam would say the same**: **it can't be defended philosophically; it's a belief.**"

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## Part 8: From What Body?

**Rav Saadia is unequivocal**: **the actual decomposed parts** of the body are **reconstituted**.

### Cremation

"**I once gave a whole shiur on cremation. God forbid: it's absolutely forbidden. The exact source** is **a big discussion: six or seven views**."

**One of the most interesting: the *Minchat Elazar*** (**the Munkatcher Rebbe**): **cremating yourself denies resurrection**: *how will you rise from ashes?*

"**My simple thought when I read that: so all the people burnt to ashes in Auschwitz won't be resurrected?**" **Rav Saadia himself**: **nothing is completely destroyed**; **from the smallest**

**atoms left, Hashem can reconstitute the body**.

| | Body at resurrection |
|---|---|
| **Rav Saadia** | **The original matter**, reconstituted |
| **Chasdai Crescas** (*Or Hashem*) and others | **Not necessarily**: Hashem can **fashion a body identical to the one you lived in** |

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## Summary

1. **Principle 13: *Techiyat HaMetim*, "already explained"**: **a foundation of the Torah, for the righteous**, and **"a person must die and return to dust"**.
2. **Sources: אני אמית ואחיה** (Ha'azinu); **Yeshayahu**, **Daniel**. **Not *gilgul***.
3. **The Rambam is terse everywhere**, and **the Ra'avad** read him as **souls only**.
4. ***Ma'amar Techiyat HaMetim*** (after a **1189 letter from Yemen**): **physical resurrection, yes**; brief because of **style**, because **it's belief, not philosophy**, and because **Olam HaBa is the main thing**. **Rise, live, die again, then Olam HaBa**: "**unique among the Rishonim**."
5. **Hints otherwise: Shapiro** (13 before 12, 11 missing); **the cemetery blessing's *lechayei Olam HaBa*** and the ***Keter Shem Tov's* והמשכיל יבין**; **Rabbi Hertz**.
6. **The ruling: *al panav* we believe in a physical resurrection**; one who understands it spiritually **"I wouldn't call a *kofer*"**.
7. **The Ramban:** resurrection **ushers in an embodied Olam HaBa**. **Rav Saadia: two resurrections**. **Albo: כשיחיו נחכם להם.**
8. **Same matter or new? Rav Saadia** vs **Crescas**; **cremation** is forbidden, but **Hashem can raise even the ashes of Auschwitz**.

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## Coming Up

**After Purim (in two weeks): the final shiur of the series**: **the Rambam's concluding paragraph**, what follows from **denying any of the Thirteen Principles**, and **how it applies today**. Then **the Moreh Nevuchim**.

"**Wishing everyone a beautiful, happy and enjoyable Purim.**"

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